

How can you best evaluate the impact of an initiative that consists of a large number of similar initiatives?

Purchasers/funders are often involved in funding multiple similar initiatives in different localities or settings. See the Group Action Planning for Implementing Multiple Similar Services or Initiatives Tool (F3) for one way of doing this. In regard to impact evaluation, there are two different ways of thinking about what 'the overall initiative' is. These two different approaches can lead to taking two different evaluation approaches. This Full Initiative Roll-Out Versus Piloting Evaluation Explainer (G16) provides a way of thinking about this.

The first option is to view it as there being one 'overall initiative', a single entity made up of many sub-initiatives. So you will be attempting to 'evaluate the overall impact of the initiative as a single enterprise' and will use one of the impact evaluation designs (G11) to attempt to attribute improvements in high-level outcomes to the overall initiative. However, a second option is to see what is happening as consisting of a large number of separate but similar initiatives being rolled out rather than just one single large initiative. This way of looking at what is happening suggests a different evaluation approach in which you think in terms of a 'piloting' phase followed by a 'full roll-out' phase, in which both phases can have different evaluation approaches. This is the way things are done in many areas, such as medicine, where randomized controlled trials are used to show that an intervention works, but when the intervention is actually rolled out and used in the field, there is just monitoring of controllable indicators rather than any attempt at impact evaluation on the full roll-out.

So, under the second option, during the piloting phase, you are likely to use a comprehensive evaluation approach, including most or all of the evaluation components from the DoView Planning Framework (D1). However, for the full roll-out at the individual initiative level, you may use a simpler approach, such just as monitoring outputs and controllable indicators, as illustrated in this tool. Since piloting has already shown that the initiative works, you are just reassuring yourself that the initiative is actually being faithfully implemented in each of the individual cases and then presuming that it will make a difference to high-level outcomes. In terms of impact evaluation designs, this approach can be seen as an Intervention Logic Model (Theory-Based) Design (see G9).